

The Rise of the Labor Movement

The Big Idea

The expansion of industry prompted laborers to form unions to better their lives.

Why It Matters Now

Many of the strategies used today in the labor movement, such as the strike, have their origins in the late 19th century.

Key Terms and People

Samuel Gompers

collective bargaining

American Federation of Labor (AFL)

Eugene V. Debs

Industrial Workers of the World (IWW)

Mary Harris Jones

One American's Story

The son of Jewish immigrants, **Samuel Gompers** came to the United States with his parents at age 13. He worked as a cigar maker and joined a local union, eventually becoming its president. Gompers would go on to become a key figure in the labor movement, dedicating his life to helping working Americans. He campaigned for basic trade-union rights, such as the right to picket and to organize boycotts and strikes. His efforts on behalf of workers helped organized labor gain national recognition and respect. Samuel Gompers had this to say in response to the question: *What does labor want?*

"We want more school-houses and less jails; more books and less arsenals; more learning and less vice; more constant work and less crime; more leisure and less greed; more justice and less revenge; in fact, more of the opportunities to cultivate our better natures, to make manhood more noble, womanhood more beautiful and childhood more happy and bright. . . . These are the demands made by labor upon modern society and in their consideration is involved the fate of civilization."

—Samuel Gompers, from a speech before the International Labor Congress, 1893

Gompers' ideas were shared by thousands of workers across the country. Soon they would join the rising labor movement to help turn these ideas into reality.



Labor leader Samuel Gompers worked tirelessly to improve working conditions and wages for American workers.

Labor Unions Emerge

As business leaders merged and consolidated their forces, it seemed necessary for workers to do the same. Although northern wages were generally higher than southern wages, exploitation and unsafe working conditions drew workers together across regions in a nationwide labor movement. Laborers—skilled and unskilled; female and male; black, brown, and white; immigrant and non-immigrant—joined together in unions to try to improve their lot.



This 1917 photograph shows a 14-year-old boy linking bed springs at a factory in Boston, Massachusetts.

LONG HOURS AND DANGER One of the largest employers, the steel mills, often demanded a seven-day workweek. Seamstresses, like factory workers in most industries, worked 12 or more hours a day, six days a week. Employees were not entitled to vacation, sick leave, unemployment compensation, or reimbursement for injuries suffered on the job.

Yet injuries were common. In dirty, poorly ventilated factories, workers had to perform repetitive, mind-dulling tasks, sometimes with dangerous or faulty equipment. In 1882 an average of 675 laborers were killed in work-related accidents each week. In addition, wages were so low that most families could not survive unless everyone held a job. Between 1890 and 1910, for example, the number of women working for wages doubled, from 4 million

to more than 8 million. Twenty percent of the boys and ten percent of the girls under age 15 also held full-time jobs. Some were as young as five years old. With little time or energy left for school, child laborers forfeited their futures to help their families make ends meet.

Not surprisingly, jobs for women and children paid the lowest wages. The pay was often as little as 27 cents for a child's 14-hour day. In 1899 women earned an average of \$267 a year, nearly half of men's average pay of \$498. In contrast, the very next year Andrew Carnegie made \$23 million—with no income tax.

Document-Based Investigation Historical Source

Sweatshops

In sweatshops, or workshops in tenements rather than in factories, workers had little choice but to put up with the conditions. Sweatshop employment, which was tedious and required few skills, was often the only avenue open to women and children. Jacob Riis described the conditions faced by "sweaters."

Analyze Historical Sources

According to Jacob Riis, how were working conditions for children in sweatshops?

"The bulk of the sweater's work is done in the tenements, which the law that regulates factory labor does not reach. . . . In [them] the child works unchallenged from the day he is old enough to pull a thread. There is no such thing as a dinner hour; men and women eat while they work, and the 'day' is lengthened at both ends far into the night."

—Jacob Riis, from *How the Other Half Lives*

EARLY LABOR ORGANIZING Skilled workers had formed small, local unions since the late 1700s. The first large-scale national organization of laborers, the National Labor Union (NLU), was formed in 1866 by ironworker William H. Sylvis. The refusal of some NLU local chapters to admit African Americans led to the creation of the Colored National Labor Union (CNLU). Isaac Meyers, a caulker from Baltimore, led the CNLU. Nevertheless, NLU membership grew to 640,000. In 1868 the NLU persuaded Congress to legalize an eight-hour day for government workers.

NLU organizers concentrated on linking existing local unions. In 1869 Uriah Stephens focused his attention on individual workers and organized the Noble Order of the Knights of Labor. Its motto was “An injury to one is the concern of all.” Membership in the Knights of Labor was officially open to all workers, regardless of race, gender, or degree of skill. Like the NLU, the Knights supported an eight-hour workday and advocated “equal pay for equal work” by men and women. They saw strikes, or refusals to work, as a last resort and instead advocated arbitration. At its height in 1886, the Knights of Labor had about 700,000 members. Although the Knights declined after the failure of a series of strikes, other unions continued to organize.

THE POWER OF UNIONS As more and more workers joined, the unions were able to exert increased power on business leaders. Unions concentrated on bread-and-butter issues—higher wages, shorter hours, better working conditions. Many union leaders felt that the best way to obtain these benefits was through **collective bargaining**. In collective bargaining, union officials representing the workers negotiate with management. If negotiation fails, workers may strike or organize a boycott to support union demands.

Some businesses had union contracts that stated that only members of the union could work there. In order to be hired at such a business, which was called a closed shop, workers had to join the union. An open shop could hire anyone. Even the threat of a strike at a closed shop could give a union much more negotiating power with management.

With increased union membership also came increased political power. Each union member was a potential voter. Unions could leverage this fact to influence sympathetic politicians. These politicians would in turn draft and pass laws favorable to labor. In addition, unions could use their influence among members to raise money for and run their own political candidates. Still, divergent ideas among union leadership managed to keep some unions from working together.

Union Movements Diverge

As labor activism spread, it diversified. Two major types of unions made great gains under forceful leaders.

CRAFT UNIONISM One form of labor organization was craft unionism, which included skilled workers from one or more trades. Samuel Gompers led the Cigar Makers’ International Union to join other craft unions in 1886. The **American Federation of Labor (AFL)**, with Gompers as its president, was

able to reach written agreements on wages, hours, and working conditions. Unlike the Knights of Labor, the AFL used strikes as a major tactic. Successful strikes helped the AFL win higher wages and shorter workweeks. Between 1890 and 1915, the average weekly wages in unionized industries rose from \$17.50 to \$24. The average workweek fell from almost 54.5 hours to just under 49 hours.

INDUSTRIAL UNIONISM Some labor leaders felt that unions should include all laborers—skilled and unskilled—in a specific industry. This concept captured the imagination of **Eugene V. Debs**, who attempted to form such an industrial union—the American Railway Union (ARU). Most of the new union’s members were unskilled and semiskilled laborers, but skilled engineers and firemen joined too. Debs believed that the strike was “the weapon of the oppressed.” In 1894 the new union won a strike for higher wages. Within two months, its membership climbed to 150,000, dwarfing the 90,000 enrolled in the four skilled railroad brotherhoods. Though the ARU, like the Knights of Labor, never recovered after the failure of a major strike, it added to the momentum of union organizing.

SOCIALISM AND THE IWW In an attempt to solve the problems faced by workers, Eugene Debs and some other labor activists eventually turned to socialism. Socialism is an economic and political system based on government control of business and property and equal distribution of wealth. Socialism carried to its extreme form is communism, as advocated by the German philosopher Karl Marx. Socialism would result in the overthrow of the capitalist system. Most socialists in late-19th-century America drew back from this goal, however, and worked within the labor movement to achieve better conditions for workers. In 1905 a group of radical unionists and socialists in Chicago organized the **Industrial Workers of the World (IWW)**, or the Wobblies. Headed by William “Big Bill” Haywood, the Wobblies included miners, lumberers, and cannery and dock workers. Unlike the ARU, the IWW welcomed African Americans, but membership never topped 100,000. Its only major strike victory occurred in 1912. Yet the Wobblies, like other industrial unions, gave dignity and a sense of solidarity to unskilled workers.



In New York City's Union Square in 1914, IWW members protest violence against striking coal miners in Colorado.



Vocabulary
arbitration a method of settling disputes in which both sides submit their differences to a mutually approved judge

Reading Check
Analyze Issues How did industrial working conditions contribute to the growth of the labor movement?

Reading Check
Compare and
Contrast How did
craft unions and
industrial unions
differ?

OTHER LABOR ACTIVISM IN THE WEST In April 1903 about 1,000 Japanese and Mexican immigrant workers organized a successful strike in the sugar-beet fields of Ventura County, California. They formed the Sugar Beet and Farm Laborers' Union of Oxnard. In Wyoming, the State Federation of Labor supported a union of Chinese and Japanese immigrant miners who sought the same wages and treatment as other union miners. These small, independent unions increased both the overall strength of the labor movement and the tension between labor and management.

Strikes Turn Violent

Industry and government responded forcefully to union activity, which they saw as a threat to the entire capitalist system.

THE GREAT STRIKE OF 1877 In July 1877 workers for the Baltimore and Ohio Railroad (B&O) struck to protest their second wage cut in two months. The work stoppage spread to other lines. Most freight and even some passenger traffic, covering over 50,000 miles, was stopped for more than a week. Several state governors asked President Rutherford B. Hayes to intervene, saying that the strikers were impeding interstate commerce. Federal troops ended the strike.

THE HAYMARKET AFFAIR Encouraged by the impact of the 1877 strike, labor leaders continued to press for change. On the evening of May 4, 1886, 3,000 people gathered at Chicago's Haymarket Square to protest police brutality. A striker had been killed and several had been wounded at the McCormick Harvester plant the day before. Rain began to fall at about 10 o'clock, and the crowd was dispersing when police arrived. Then someone tossed a bomb into the police line. Police fired on the workers. Seven police officers and several workers died in the chaos that followed. No one ever learned who threw the bomb, but the three speakers at the demonstration and five other radicals were charged with inciting a riot. All eight were convicted; four were hanged and one committed suicide in prison. The three surviving men were later pardoned by the governor of Illinois. He justified the pardon because he believed that the accused had not received a fair trial. After Haymarket, the public began to turn against the labor movement.

THE HOMESTEAD STRIKE Despite the violence and rising public anger, workers continued to strike. On June 29, 1892, after company president Henry Clay Frick announced his plan to cut wages, workers at the Carnegie Steel Company's Homestead plant in Pennsylvania called a strike. Frick hired armed guards from the Pinkerton Detective Agency to protect the plant so that he could hire scabs, or strikebreakers, to keep it operating. In a pitched battle, at least three detectives and nine workers died. The steelworkers forced out the Pinkertons and kept the plant closed until the Pennsylvania National Guard arrived on July 12. The strike continued until November, but by then the union had lost much of its support and gave in to the company. It would take 45 years for steelworkers to mobilize once again.

THE PULLMAN COMPANY STRIKE Strikes continued in other industries, however. During the panic of 1893 and the economic depression that followed, the Pullman company laid off more than 3,000 of its 5,800 employees. It cut the wages of the rest by 25 to 50 percent, without cutting the cost of its employee housing. After paying their rent, many workers took home less than \$6 a week. A strike was called in the spring of 1894, when the Pullman company failed to restore wages or decrease rents. Eugene Debs asked for arbitration, but Pullman refused to negotiate with the strikers. So the ARU began boycotting Pullman trains.

After Pullman hired strikebreakers, the strike turned violent. President Grover Cleveland sent in federal troops. In the bitter aftermath, Debs was jailed. Pullman fired most of the strikers, and the railroads blacklisted many others, so they could never again get railroad jobs.

WOMEN ORGANIZE Although women were barred from many unions, they united behind powerful leaders to demand better working conditions, equal pay for equal work, and an end to child labor. Perhaps the most prominent organizer in the women's labor movement was **Mary Harris Jones**. Jones supported the Great Strike of 1877 and later organized for the United Mine Workers of America (UMW). She endured death threats and jail with the coal miners, who gave her the nickname Mother Jones. In 1903, to expose the cruelties of child labor, she led 80 mill children—many with hideous injuries—on a march to the home of President Theodore Roosevelt. Their crusade influenced the passage of child labor laws.

— BIOGRAPHY —



Eugene V. Debs (1855–1926)

Born in Indiana, Eugene V. Debs left home at the age of 14 to work for the railroads. In 1875 he helped organize a local lodge of the Brotherhood of Locomotive Firemen. After attempts to unite the local railroad brotherhoods failed, Debs organized the American Railway Union.

While in prison following the Pullman strike in 1894, Debs read the works of Karl Marx. He became increasingly disillusioned with capitalism. He became a spokesperson for the Socialist Party of America and was its candidate for president five times. In 1912 he won about 900,000 votes—an amazing 6 percent of the total.



Mother Jones (1830–1930)

Mary Harris "Mother" Jones was a native of Ireland who immigrated to North America as a child. She became involved in the American labor movement after receiving assistance from the Knights of Labor. According to a reporter who followed "the mother of the laboring class" on her children's march in 1903, "She fights their battles with a Mother's Love." Jones continued fighting until her death at age 100.

Jones was definitely not the kind of woman admired by industrialists. "God almighty made women," she declared, "and the Rockefeller gang of thieves made ladies."



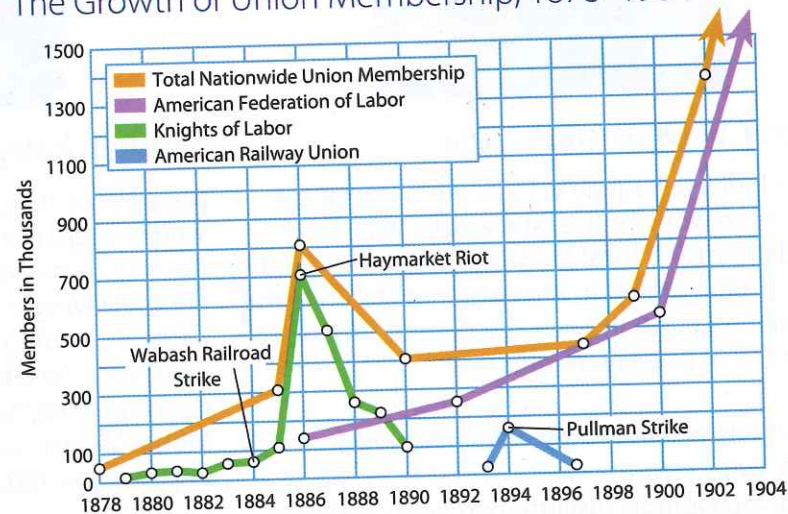
The fire department's ladders reached only to the sixth floor, two floors below the burning Triangle Shirtwaist Company.

Other organizers also achieved significant gains for women. In 1909 Pauline Newman, just 16 years old, became the first female organizer of the International Ladies' Garment Workers' Union (ILGWU). A garment worker from the age of eight, Newman also supported the "Uprising of the 20,000." This 1909 seamstresses' strike won labor agreements and improved working conditions for some strikers.

The public could no longer ignore conditions in garment factories after a fire broke out at the Triangle Shirtwaist factory in New York City on March 25, 1911. The fire spread swiftly through the oil-soaked machines and piles of cloth, engulfing the eighth, ninth, and tenth floors. As workers, mostly immigrant women, attempted to flee, they discovered that the company had locked all but one of the exit doors to prevent theft. The unlocked door was blocked by fire. The factory had no sprinkler system, and the single fire escape collapsed almost immediately. In all, 146 women died. Some were found huddled with their faces raised to a small window. Public outrage flared after a jury acquitted the factory owners of manslaughter. In response, the state of New York set up a task force to study factory working conditions.

During the Paterson Silk Strike of 1913, women actually gained a place among male union leadership. Encouraged by the IWW, local leaders, such as Italian immigrant Carrie Golzio and Jewish immigrant Hannah Silverman, held "women only" meetings for female weavers. The silk workers were demanding a halt to the new four-loom system, which required a worker to run four room-sized looms, instead of two. For nearly five months, striking

The Growth of Union Membership, 1878–1904



Interpret Graphs

- Which union's membership increased in 1889–1890?
- What effect(s) did the Haymarket Riot have on union membership?

workers shut down all 300 silk mills and dye houses in Paterson, New Jersey, the center of the American silk industry. Even though the strike was ultimately a failure, the strikers did manage to put aside their differences in gender, ethnicity, and skill level to unite for a common cause.

MANAGEMENT AND GOVERNMENT PRESSURE UNIONS The more powerful the unions became, the more employers came to fear them. Management refused to recognize unions as representatives of the workers. Many employers forbade union meetings and fired union members. They also forced new employees to sign "yellow-dog contracts," swearing that they would not join a union.

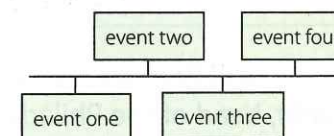
Business leaders, mainly in the South, also took advantage of state laws that allowed them to hire prison laborers at much lower wages than free laborers. In Tennessee, this led to the Coal Creek Saga. When mine owners at Coal Creek replaced free workers with prisoners, armed miners, over the course of a year, repeatedly attacked the company's buildings, freeing hundreds of convicts. Although the uprising was ultimately put down in 1892, and many of the armed miners arrested, the events did fuel public outrage. By 1896 Tennessee ended its practice of allowing businesses to hire prison laborers.

Finally, industrial leaders, with the help of the courts, turned the Sherman Antitrust Act against labor. All a company had to do was say that a strike, picket line, or boycott would hurt interstate trade, and the state or federal government would issue an injunction against the labor action. Legal limitations made it more and more difficult for unions to be effective. Despite these pressures, workers—especially those in skilled jobs—continued to view unions as a powerful tool. By 1904 the AFL had about 1,700,000 members in its affiliated unions. By the eve of World War I, AFL membership would climb to over 2 million.

Reading Check
Summarize What factors made the Triangle Shirtwaist fire so lethal?

Lesson 4 Assessment

- Organize Information** Make a timeline of the notable achievements and setbacks of the labor movement between 1876 and 1913.



In what ways did strikes threaten industry?

- Key Terms and People** For each term or person in the lesson, write a sentence explaining its significance.

- Evaluate** What influence do you think unions and labor leaders had in improving working conditions and wages for American workers?

Think About:

- their tactics and strategies
- their organizational abilities
- their influence on public opinion

- Make Inferences** How might things have turned out differently if Eugene Debs had succeeded in pushing for arbitration before the Pullman Strike?
- Hypothesize** If the government had supported unions instead of management in the late 19th century, how might the lives of workers have been different?